IDIOMS y EXPRESIONES

Nivel C2

Idioms and fixed expressions · modismos

Un idiom es una expresión fija cuyo sentido no se deduce de sus palabras: se aprende en bloque.

1 ¿Qué es un idiom?

spill the beans	= irse de la lengua
hit the nail on the head	= dar en el clavo

Su sentido es figurado: no se deduce palabra por palabra.

2 Fijo y variable

- El verbo se conjuga: she threw in the towel
- El posesivo concuerda: I bit my tongue
- Fijos: sustantivos, artículos y partículas
- Casi nunca admiten pasiva

3 Registro

- Coloquial: a piece of cake, spill the beans
- Prensa: at the eleventh hour, in hot water
- Ensayo académico: mejor una paráfrasis

4 Por temas

trabajo · dinero · éxito · conflicto · emociones · riesgo · tiempo · saber

Apréndelos agrupados y con un ejemplo.

5 Trampas de traducción

un ojo de la cara	→ an arm and a leg
me suena a chino	→ it's all Greek to me
tirar la toalla	→ throw in the towel

7 Error común

✗ It cost an eye of the face.

✓ It cost an arm and a leg.

Los idioms no se traducen palabra por palabra.

6 Consejo rápido

- Aprende el bloque entero, con su partícula.
- Uno o dos por texto: no los encadenes.
- ¿Dudas del registro? Parafrasea.

Mini ejercicio

Completa el idiom con una palabra.
Complete the idiom with one word.

1. Don't beat about the _____. Tell me!
2. The exam? A piece of _____!
3. Is that true, or are you pulling my _____?
4. We've done our part: the ball is in your _____.
5. After three defeats, she threw in the _____.

Explicación · Explanation

Lee cada recuadro despacio. Primero en español, luego en inglés. Read each box slowly: first in Spanish, then in English.

¿Qué es? · What is it?

Un **idiom** es una expresión fija cuyo significado no se deduce de la suma de sus palabras: spill the beans no tiene nada que ver con judías; significa **irse de la lengua**. En C2 se espera que los reconozcas al instante en la prensa, la literatura y la conversación, y que uses los más frecuentes con naturalidad, respetando su **forma exacta** y su **registro**. Algunos coinciden con el español (the tip of the iceberg), muchos usan otra imagen (cost an arm and a leg = costar un ojo de la cara) y otros son auténticas trampas.

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose meaning cannot be worked out from its individual words. At C2 you should recognise idioms instantly and use the common ones accurately, in their exact form and in the right register.

spill the beans + ≠ + derramar las judías

spill the beans + = + irse de la lengua

1 · Bloque fijo, piezas móviles · Fixed chunk, moving parts

Un idiom es un bloque, pero no está congelado del todo. **Lo que cambia:** el verbo se conjuga (she **threw** in the towel), los posesivos concuerdan con el sujeto (I bit **my** tongue · they pulled **their** weight) y algunos tienen un hueco para la persona (pull **someone's** leg → pull **my** leg). **Lo que no cambia:** los sustantivos, los artículos, las preposiciones y el número (~~throw the towel~~, ~~beat about the bushes~~). Muy pocos admiten pasiva sin perder el sentido figurado: the hatchet has been buried se oye, pero ~~the bush was beaten about~~ suena absurdo.

Verbs change tense, possessives agree with the subject and some idioms have a slot for a person. Nouns, articles, prepositions and number are fixed. Most idioms resist the passive.

verbo conjugable + parte fija

pull + someone's + leg → pull + my + leg

The consortium finally **threw in the towel** after its third bid.
→ El consorcio por fin tiró la toalla tras su tercera oferta.

Are you **pulling my leg**?
→ ¿Me estás tomando el pelo?

She was my boss, so I had to **bite my tongue**.
→ Era mi jefa, así que tuve que morderme la lengua.

The hatchet has finally **been buried**.
→ Por fin se ha enterrado el hacha de guerra.

2 · No todos tienen el mismo registro · Register

Hay idioms **neutros**, habituales en la prensa seria y en los informes (a bone of contention, the tip of the iceberg, at the eleventh hour, in the red); idioms **coloquiales**, propios de la conversación y de la prensa popular (a piece of cake, spill the beans, get the sack), y algunos **muy británicos e informales** (take the mickey). En un ensayo académico lo más seguro es sustituir el idiom por una paráfrasis.

Neutral idioms appear in quality journalism and reports; colloquial ones belong to conversation and the tabloids. In academic writing, paraphrase.

Pay remains **a bone of contention** between unions and management. (prensa)
→ El salario sigue siendo la manzana de la discordia entre sindicatos y dirección.

Talks collapsed **at the eleventh hour**. (prensa)
→ Las negociaciones fracasaron en el último momento.

Honestly, the interview was **a piece of cake**. (coloquial)
→ La verdad, la entrevista fue pan comido.

Are you **taking the mickey**? (muy coloquial, BrE)
→ ¿Me estás vacilando?

Idiomático o formal · Idiomatic or formal?

El mismo contenido en dos registros. En un informe, una carta formal o un ensayo, sustituye el idiom coloquial por un verbo o una expresión neutra.

Same content, two registers: in reports and essays, replace colloquial idioms with neutral wording.

Idiomático · informal

- We're **in the red**.
- She **threw in the towel**.
- Stop **beating about the bush**.
- It **cost an arm and a leg**.
- He **got the sack**.
- The plan **went down the drain**.

Formal · académico

- The company is **operating at a loss**.
- She **abandoned the attempt**.
- Please **come to the point**.
- It was **prohibitively expensive**.
- He **was dismissed**.
- The plan **came to nothing**.

Trabajo y dinero · Work and money

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
cost an arm and a leg be extremely expensive	costar un ojo de la cara	Renting in central London **costs an arm and a leg**. Alquilar en el centro de Londres cuesta un ojo de la cara.
make ends meet have just enough money to live on	llegar a fin de mes	Many nurses are struggling to **make ends meet**. Muchas enfermeras tienen dificultades para llegar a fin de mes.
tighten your belt spend less money	apretarse el cinturón	After the merger, every department had to **tighten its belt**. Tras la fusión, todos los departamentos tuvieron que apretarse el cinturón.

Trabajo y dinero · Work and money (continúa · cont.)

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
be in the red be losing money; be in debt	estar en números rojos	The airline has **been in the red** since the pandemic. La aerolínea está en números rojos desde la pandemia.
learn the ropes learn how a job is done	aprender el oficio, hacerse con el puesto	Give the new analyst a few weeks to **learn the ropes**. Dale al nuevo analista unas semanas para hacerse con el puesto.
pull your weight do your fair share of the work	arrimar el hombro	If one member doesn't **pull their weight**, the whole team suffers. Si un miembro no arrima el hombro, todo el equipo lo paga.
get the sack be dismissed from your job	ser despedido, que te echen	He **got the sack** for leaking confidential data. Lo echaron por filtrar datos confidenciales.
a cash cow a reliable source of profit	la gallina de los huevos de oro	The subscription service has become the firm's **cash cow**. Las suscripciones se han convertido en la gallina de los huevos de oro de la empresa.
back to the drawing board time to start planning again	volver a empezar desde cero	The investors rejected the plan, so it's **back to the drawing board**. Los inversores rechazaron el plan, así que toca volver a empezar.

Éxito, fracaso y esfuerzo · Success, failure and effort

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
hit the nail on the head describe something exactly right	dar en el clavo	Your analysis **hit the nail on the head**. Tu análisis dio en el clavo.
a piece of cake something very easy	pan comido, coser y cantar	After all that revision, the exam was **a piece of cake**. Después de tanto repasar, el examen fue pan comido.
throw in the towel give up	tirar la toalla	After three failed bids, the consortium **threw in the towel**. Tras tres ofertas fallidas, el consorcio tiró la toalla.
go down the drain be wasted	irse al traste, tirarse por la borda	Years of research **went down the drain** when funding was cut. Años de investigación se fueron al traste con el recorte.

Éxito, fracaso y esfuerzo · Success, failure and effort (continúa · cont.)

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
bite off more than you can chew take on more than you can manage	abarcar demasiado (quien mucho abarca, poco aprieta)	With three part-time jobs, she's **bitten off more than she can chew**. Con tres trabajos a tiempo parcial, ha abarcado más de lo que puede.
a long shot something unlikely to succeed	una posibilidad remota	It's **a long shot**, but we might still win the contract. Es muy improbable, pero aún podríamos ganar el contrato.
fall flat fail to have the intended effect	no surtir efecto, no hacer ninguna gracia	His attempt at humour **fell** completely **flat**. Su intento de hacer gracia no tuvo ningún éxito.
burn the midnight oil work late into the night	quemarse las pestañas	She **burnt the midnight oil** to finish her thesis. Se quemó las pestañas para terminar la tesis.
go the extra mile make more effort than is expected	ir más allá, darlo todo	Our staff always **go the extra mile** for clients. Nuestro personal siempre va más allá de lo que se le pide.

Comunicación y conflicto · Communication and conflict

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
beat about the bush avoid the main point	andarse con rodeos	Stop **beating about the bush** and tell me what happened. Deja de andarte con rodeos y dime qué pasó.
spill the beans reveal a secret	irse de la lengua	Someone **spilt the beans** about the takeover. Alguien se fue de la lengua sobre la adquisición.
let the cat out of the bag reveal a secret by accident	descubrir el pastel	I **let the cat out of the bag** about her surprise party. Descubrí el pastel de su fiesta sorpresa.
bite your tongue stop yourself from saying something	morderse la lengua	I had to **bite my tongue** during the meeting. Tuve que morderme la lengua en la reunión.
put your foot in it say something tactless	meter la pata	I really **put my foot in it** when I mentioned his ex. Metí la pata hasta el fondo al mencionar a su ex.

Comunicación y conflicto · Communication and conflict (continúa · cont.)

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
bury the hatchet make peace after a quarrel	hacer las paces, enterrar el hacha de guerra	The two ministers have finally **buried the hatchet**. Los dos ministros por fin han hecho las paces.
a bone of contention a subject of disagreement	la manzana de la discordia	The budget remains **a bone of contention**. El presupuesto sigue siendo la manzana de la discordia.
the elephant in the room an obvious problem nobody mentions	el tema incómodo que todos evitan	Climate change was **the elephant in the room** at the summit. El cambio climático era el tema que nadie quería tocar en la cumbre.
get on someone's nerves irritate someone	sacar de quicio, poner de los nervios	His constant interruptions **get on my nerves**. Sus constantes interrupciones me sacan de quicio.

Emociones y relaciones · Emotions and relationships

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
over the moon extremely pleased	loco de contento, en el séptimo cielo	She was **over the moon** about the scholarship. Estaba loca de contenta con la beca.
down in the dumps sad, low	de bajón, con la moral por los suelos	He's been **down in the dumps** since the election. Está de bajón desde las elecciones.
see eye to eye agree	estar de acuerdo	We don't always **see eye to eye** on politics. No siempre estamos de acuerdo en política.
get cold feet become too nervous to go ahead	echarse atrás, rajarse	The buyer **got cold feet** at the last minute. El comprador se echó atrás en el último momento.
have a chip on your shoulder feel resentful about a past injustice	estar resentido, tener complejo	He **has a chip on his shoulder** about not going to university. Está resentido por no haber ido a la universidad.
not your cup of tea not something you like	no ser lo tuyo	Opera isn't really **my cup of tea**. La ópera no es lo mío.

Emociones y relaciones · Emotions and relationships (continúa · cont.)

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
keep someone at arm's length avoid becoming close to someone	mantener a alguien a distancia	She keeps journalists at arm's length. Mantiene a los periodistas a distancia.
be head over heels (in love) be completely in love	estar perdidamente enamorado	They're head over heels in love. Están perdidamente enamorados.

Decisiones, riesgo y tiempo · Decisions, risk and time

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
sit on the fence avoid taking sides	no mojarse, nadar entre dos aguas	The senator is still sitting on the fence over the bill. El senador sigue sin mojarse sobre el proyecto de ley.
take the plunge finally do something risky	lanzarse a la piscina, dar el paso	After years of renting, they took the plunge and bought a flat. Tras años de alquiler, dieron el paso y compraron un piso.
play it by ear decide as things happen	improvisar sobre la marcha	I don't know how long the talks will last, so let's play it by ear. No sé cuánto durarán las negociaciones, así que ya iremos viendo.
jump the gun act too soon	precipitarse, adelantarse	The newspaper jumped the gun by announcing the result. El periódico se precipitó al anunciar el resultado.
a blessing in disguise something bad that turns out to be good	no hay mal que por bien no venga	Losing that job was a blessing in disguise. Perder aquel trabajo fue, al final, una suerte.
the ball is in your court it is your turn to act or decide	la pelota está en tu tejado	We've made our offer; the ball is in their court now. Hemos hecho nuestra oferta; ahora la pelota está en su tejado.
cross that bridge when you come to it deal with a problem only if it arises	no adelantar acontecimientos	What if they say no? We'll cross that bridge when we come to it. ¿Y si dicen que no? No adelantemos acontecimientos.
once in a blue moon very rarely	de Pascuas a Ramos	My brother phones once in a blue moon. Mi hermano llama de Pascuas a Ramos.

Decisiones, riesgo y tiempo · Decisions, risk and time (continúa · cont.)

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
in the nick of time just in time	justo a tiempo, por los pelos	The firefighters arrived **in the nick of time**. Los bomberos llegaron justo a tiempo.
at the eleventh hour at the last possible moment	en el último momento, a última hora	A deal was struck **at the eleventh hour**. Se cerró un acuerdo en el último momento.

Saber, entender y meterse en líos · Knowledge and trouble

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
know something inside out know something thoroughly	conocer algo al dedillo	She **knows** the tax code **inside out**. Se conoce el código tributario al dedillo.
ring a bell sound familiar	sonar (de algo)	Does the name Hargreaves **ring a bell**? ¿Te suena el nombre de Hargreaves?
it's all Greek to me I can't understand it at all	me suena a chino	Quantum physics? **It's all Greek to me**. ¿Física cuántica? Me suena a chino.
the tip of the iceberg a small visible part of a bigger problem	la punta del iceberg	These complaints are just **the tip of the iceberg**. Estas quejas son solo la punta del iceberg.
be in hot water be in trouble	estar metido en un lío	The minister **is in hot water** over his expenses. El ministro está metido en un lío por sus gastos.
a storm in a teacup a lot of fuss about something unimportant	una tormenta en un vaso de agua	The row over the logo was **a storm in a teacup**. La polémica del logo fue una tormenta en un vaso de agua.
between a rock and a hard place facing two equally bad options	entre la espada y la pared	The government is **between a rock and a hard place**. El Gobierno está entre la espada y la pared.
the last straw the final problem that makes things unbearable	la gota que colma el vaso	The latest delay was **the last straw** for passengers. El último retraso fue la gota que colmó el vaso para los pasajeros.

Saber, entender y meterse en líos · Knowledge and trouble (continúa · cont.)

Idiom · meaning	Español	Ejemplo · Example
face the music accept the consequences of your actions	dar la cara, afrontar las consecuencias	Sooner or later, the directors will have to face the music. Tarde o temprano, los directivos tendrán que dar la cara.

Trampas de traducción · Translation traps

Español	✗ Calco	✓ Inglés natural
costar un ojo de la cara	~~cost an eye of the face~~	cost an arm and a leg
tirar la toalla	~~throw the towel~~	throw in the towel
estar en las nubes	~~be in the clouds~~	have your head in the clouds
tomar el pelo	~~take the hair~~	pull someone's leg · take the mickey (out of someone)
meter la pata	~~put the leg~~	put your foot in it
me suena a chino	~~it sounds Chinese to me~~	it's all Greek to me
la gota que colma el vaso	~~the drop that fills the glass~~	the last straw
matar dos pájaros de un tiro	~~kill two birds with one shot~~	kill two birds with one stone
estar en el mismo barco	~~be in the same ship~~	be in the same boat
tener mariposas en el estómago (amor)	falso amigo parcial	have butterflies in your stomach = sobre todo nervios (before an exam)

🇪🇸 Pull someone's leg = engañar a alguien en broma; take the mickey (out of someone) = burlarse de alguien (muy británico y coloquial). Algunos idioms coinciden casi palabra por palabra (the tip of the iceberg, read between the lines), pero son la excepción, no la regla.

🇬🇧 Pull someone's leg = tease someone with a false story; take the mickey = mock someone (very British, informal). Word-for-word equivalents exist, but they are the exception.

Idioms en contexto · Idioms in context

- The design was rejected, so it's **back to the drawing board**.
  → Rechazaron el diseño, así que toca volver a empezar.
- We'll have to **tighten our belts** until the new contract is signed.
  → Tendremos que apretarnos el cinturón hasta que se firme el nuevo contrato.
- You've **hit the nail on the head**: the real problem is the lack of training.
  → Has dado en el clavo: el verdadero problema es la falta de formación.
- I was dying to reply, but I **bit my tongue**.
  → Me moría de ganas de contestar, pero me mordí la lengua.
- After years of rivalry, the two families have **buried the hatchet**.
  → Tras años de rivalidad, las dos familias han hecho las paces.
- Nobody dared to mention **the elephant in the room**: the chief executive's salary.
  → Nadie se atrevió a mencionar el tema incómodo: el sueldo del consejero delegado.
- Winning the league is **a long shot** for a club like ours.
  → Ganar la liga es muy improbable para un club como el nuestro.
- She's been **down in the dumps** since her dog died.
  → Está de bajón desde que se le murió el perro.
- Heavy metal is **not my cup of tea**, I'm afraid.
  → Me temo que el heavy metal no es lo mío.
- After years of hesitation, he **took the plunge** and moved to Dublin.
  → Tras años de dudas, se lanzó a la piscina y se mudó a Dublín.
- His face **rings a bell**, but I can't remember his name.
  → Su cara me suena, pero no recuerdo cómo se llama.
- After twenty years in the post, she knows the system **inside out**.
  → Tras veinte años en el puesto, conoce el sistema al dedillo.

Idioms en contexto · Idioms in context (continúa · cont.)

- The row about the new logo is just **a storm in a teacup**.
  → La polémica del nuevo logo no es más que una tormenta en un vaso de agua.
- Sooner or later, the bankers will have to **face the music**.
  → Tarde o temprano, los banqueros tendrán que dar la cara.
- We're all **in the same boat**, so let's stop complaining.
  → Estamos todos en el mismo barco, así que dejemos de quejarnos.
- We only see our cousins **once in a blue moon**.
  → Solo vemos a nuestros primos de Pascuas a Ramos.
- His constant interruptions really **get on my nerves**.
  → Sus constantes interrupciones me sacan de quicio.
- With two jobs and a baby, I've **bitten off more than I can chew**.
  → Con dos trabajos y un bebé, he abarcado más de lo que puedo.
- Come on, **spill the beans**: who got the job?
  → Venga, desembucha: ¿a quién le han dado el puesto?
- Sorry, I **had my head in the clouds**. Could you repeat the question?
  → Perdona, estaba en las nubes. ¿Puedes repetir la pregunta?
- I always **have butterflies in my stomach** before a job interview.
  → Siempre tengo un nudo en el estómago antes de una entrevista de trabajo.
- Cycling to work **kills two birds with one stone**: I save money and keep fit.
  → Ir en bici al trabajo es matar dos pájaros de un tiro: ahorro dinero y me mantengo en forma.
- Investors were warned not to **jump the gun** before the figures were published.
  → Se advirtió a los inversores de que no se precipitaran antes de que se publicaran las cifras.
- He's got **a chip on his shoulder** about his accent, although nobody else notices it.
  → Tiene complejo con su acento, aunque nadie más se da cuenta.

¡Caza al monstruo! · Hunt the monster

Trampas Españolas

✗ ~~The renovation cost us an eye of the face.~~
✓ The renovation cost us **an arm and a leg**.
Calco de «un ojo de la cara»: en inglés se paga con un brazo y una pierna. / Literal calque; the English image is an arm and a leg.

✗ ~~After the third rejection, she threw the towel.~~
✓ After the third rejection, she threw **in** the towel.
La partícula forma parte del bloque fijo: **throw in** the towel. / The particle in is part of the idiom.

✗ ~~Sorry, I was in the clouds.~~
✓ Sorry, I had **my head in the clouds**.
«Estar en las nubes» no se traduce literalmente; también vale I was miles away. / Use have your head in the clouds or be miles away.

✗ ~~Quantum physics sounds Chinese to me.~~
✓ Quantum physics **is all Greek to me**.
Cada idioma elige su lengua incomprensible: en inglés es el griego. / English uses Greek, not Chinese.

✗ ~~Stop beating about the bushes.~~
✓ Stop beating about the **bush**.
El número es fijo: singular. (BrE about, AmE around.) / Number is fixed: bush, singular.

✗ ~~This plan kills two birds with one shot.~~
✓ This plan kills two birds with one **stone**.
Casi idéntico al español… pero con piedra, no con tiro. / Almost the same as Spanish, but with a stone.

✗ ~~I put the leg when I asked about her husband.~~
✓ I **put my foot in it** when I asked about her husband.
«Meter la pata» → pie (foot), no pierna, y con **in it**. / The idiom is put your foot in it.

¡Caza al monstruo! · Hunt the monster (cont.)

Trampas Españolas

✗ ~~In conclusion, the reforms went down the drain.~~ ~~(ensayo)~~
✓ In conclusion, the reforms **proved ineffective**.
Registro: en un ensayo académico el idiom coloquial desentona. / Too colloquial for an academic essay: paraphrase.

¿Cómo uso un idiom sin meter la pata? · Using an idiom safely

1. Comprueba el **significado figurado** y la connotación: ¿positiva, negativa, irónica?
   Check the figurative meaning and its connotation.
2. Aprende el **bloque completo**, con su artículo y su partícula: throw **in** the towel, **a** piece of cake.
   Learn the whole chunk, with its article and particle.
3. Identifica las **piezas móviles**: tiempo verbal, posesivo (my / your / their) y hueco de persona (someone's).
   Identify the moving parts: tense, possessive, person slot.
4. Decide el **registro**: ¿conversación, columna de opinión, informe, ensayo?
   Decide the register: chat, column, report or essay?
5. No traduzcas la imagen española: busca el **equivalente funcional** (un ojo de la cara → an arm and a leg).
   Don't translate the Spanish image: find the functional equivalent.
6. Dosifica: **uno o dos** por párrafo como mucho. Encadenar idioms suena forzado.
   One or two per paragraph at most.

Texto modelo: en la oficina · Model text: at the office

James You look **down in the dumps**. What's up?
Te veo de bajón. ¿Qué pasa?

Clara The client **got cold feet** and pulled out of the deal **at the eleventh hour**.
El cliente se echó atrás y se retiró del acuerdo en el último momento.

James Oh no. So months of work have **gone down the drain**?
Vaya. ¿Así que meses de trabajo se han ido al traste?

Clara Pretty much. And I **put my foot in it** by telling the boss it would be **a piece of cake**.
Más o menos. Y metí la pata al decirle al jefe que sería pan comido.

James Don't **throw in the towel** yet. It might be **a blessing in disguise**.
No tires la toalla todavía. A lo mejor no hay mal que por bien no venga.

Clara I doubt it. Winning a new client this quarter is **a long shot**.
Lo dudo. Conseguir un cliente nuevo este trimestre es muy improbable.

James Well, I'll **go the extra mile** to help. We're **in the same boat**, after all.
Bueno, haré lo que haga falta para ayudar. Al fin y al cabo, estamos en el mismo barco.

Clara Thanks. Should we tell the boss now, or **cross that bridge when we come to it**?
Gracias. ¿Se lo decimos ya al jefe o esperamos a ver qué pasa?

James Now. If he hears it from someone else, we'll **be in hot water**.
Ya. Si se entera por otra persona, nos meteremos en un lío.

Clara True. Time to **face the music**, then. But coffee first!
Es verdad. Pues toca dar la cara. ¡Pero primero, un café!

Truco: la prueba del titular · The headline test

Antes de usar un idiom en un texto formal, pregúntate: **¿lo vería en un titular de un periódico serio o en un informe oficial?** At the eleventh hour, a bone of contention o the tip of the iceberg, sí; a piece of cake o take the mickey, no. Y dosifica: el diálogo modelo de esta sección está cargado a propósito para practicar, pero en la vida real **menos es más**; un texto lleno de idioms suena a libro de texto, no a nativo.

Would you see it in a quality newspaper headline or an official report? If not, keep it for conversation. And remember: less is more.

Ejercicios · Practice

Escribe con lápiz y letra clara. Antes de escribir, piensa qué regla toca. Write in pencil. Think about the rule first.

Name · Nombre _____ Date · Fecha _____ Score _____

Ejercicio 1 Idiom y significado · Match idiom and meaning

Une cada idiom con su significado en inglés.
Match each idiom with its meaning.

1 make ends meet	a know it thoroughly
2 learn the ropes	b refuse to take sides
3 jump the gun	c have just enough money to live on
4 sit on the fence	d a subject people disagree about
5 a bone of contention	e find out how a job is done
6 once in a blue moon	f very rarely
7 know something inside out	g act before the right moment
8 face the music	h accept the consequences of your actions

Ejercicio 2 Idiom y equivalente español · Match idiom and Spanish equivalent

Une cada idiom con su equivalente funcional en español (no con su traducción literal).
Match each idiom with its Spanish equivalent.

1 cost an arm and a leg	a la pelota está en tu tejado
2 the last straw	b me suena a chino
3 between a rock and a hard place	c costar un ojo de la cara
4 put your foot in it	d tomar el pelo
5 pull someone's leg	e meter la pata
6 it's all Greek to me	f la gota que colma el vaso
7 the ball is in your court	g no hay mal que por bien no venga
8 a blessing in disguise	h entre la espada y la pared

Ejercicio 3 Clasifica por tema · Sort by topic

✍️ Escribe cada idiom en la caja de su tema.
🇬🇧 Write each idiom under the right topic.

Word bank
bite your tongue · take the plunge · over the moon · get cold feet · a bone of contention · at the eleventh hour · down in the dumps · make ends meet · bury the hatchet · a cash cow · get on someone's nerves · in the nick of time · be in the red · tighten your belt · sit on the fence · have a chip on your shoulder

💰 Trabajo y dinero	💬 Conflicto	❤️ Emociones	🎲 Decisiones y tiempo

Ejercicio 4 La palabra fija · The fixed word

✍️ Rodea la única palabra que forma el idiom correcto.
🇬🇧 Circle the only word that completes the idiom correctly.

1. After three failed bids, they threw in / out / away the towel.
2. Stop beating about the bush / bushes / tree and tell me.
3. Renting a flat here costs an arm and a leg / foot / hand.
4. The row over the logo was a storm in a teacup / glass / bottle.
5. We can't afford new staff: the company is in the red / black / blue.
6. My brother only phones once in a blue / full / new moon.
7. The firefighters arrived in the nick / neck / knock of time.
8. I really put my foot / leg / hand in it when I mentioned his ex.

Ejercicio 4 La palabra fija · The fixed word (continúa · cont.)

9. The pay freeze was the last straw / drop / glass for the nurses.
10. We'll cross that bridge / river / road when we come to it.

Ejercicio 5 ¿Qué significa de verdad? · What does it really mean?

✍️ ¿Verdadero (T) o falso (F)? Si es falso, piensa cuál es el significado correcto.
🇬🇧 True or false? If false, think of the correct meaning.

1. If something is **a long shot**, it is very likely to succeed. T F
2. If you **get cold feet**, you become too nervous to go ahead. T F
3. **A cash cow** is a business that loses money every year. T F

Ejercicio 5 ¿Qué significa de verdad? · What does it really mean? (continúa · cont.)

4 If you **see eye to eye** with someone, you agree with them. T F

5 If a joke **falls flat**, everyone laughs at it. T F

6 When you **burn the midnight oil**, you work late into the night. T F

7 If a company is **in the red**, it is making a healthy profit. T F

8 If you **bite your tongue**, you say exactly what you think. T F

9 **A storm in a teacup** is a lot of fuss about something unimportant. T F

10 If you **keep someone at arm's length**, you avoid becoming close to them. T F

Ejercicio 6 Completa el idiom · Complete the idiom

Completa cada idiom con una palabra del recuadro.
Complete each idiom with a word from the box.

Word bank: cake · hatchet · ropes · iceberg · plunge · fence · drain · ear · bell · weight

1 Don't worry about the exam: it'll be a piece of _____.

2 The two rival chefs have finally buried the _____.

3 It took me a couple of months to learn the _____.

4 These complaints are just the tip of the _____.

5 After years of renting, they took the _____ and bought a house.

Ejercicio 6 Completa el idiom · Complete the idiom (continúa · cont.)

6 You can't sit on the _____ for ever: which side are you on?

7 All that investment went down the _____ when the project was cancelled.

8 I'm not sure when I'll finish, so let's play it by _____.

9 Hargreaves? The name rings a _____, but I can't place him.

10 Everyone in this team needs to pull their _____.

Ejercicio 7 Español, idiom y significado · Spanish, idiom and meaning

Completa las casillas vacías: el idiom inglés, su equivalente español o su significado.
Fill in the empty boxes: the English idiom, its Spanish equivalent or its meaning.

Español	Idiom	Meaning · significado
llegar a fin de mes	_____	have just enough money to live on
dar en el clavo	_____	describe something exactly right
_____	beat about the bush	avoid the main point
no mojarse	_____	avoid taking sides
_____	a bone of contention	a subject of disagreement
quemarse las pestañas	_____	work late into the night
_____	be in hot water	be in trouble
lanzarse a la piscina	_____	_____
_____	get cold feet	_____
arrimar el hombro	_____	do your fair share of the work

Ejercicio 8 Ordena la frase · Put the words in order

Ordena las fichas para formar una frase con un idiom. Ojo con las partes fijas.
Put the tiles in order to make a sentence with an idiom.

1. the · she · towel · in · threw · finally

_____

2. an arm · it · a leg · cost · and · us

_____

Ejercicio 8 Ordena la frase · Put the words in order (continúa · cont.)

3. court · the ball · in · is · your · now

_____

4. the · tip · just · of · is · this · iceberg · the

_____

Ejercicio 8 Ordena la frase · Put the words in order (continúa · cont.)

5 my | bite | had | I | to | tongue

6 eye | don't | we | eye | to | see | always

7 you | pulling | my | leg | are | ?

8 when | we | come | that bridge | to it | cross | we'll

9 make | to | struggling | ends | are | meet | many families

Ejercicio 9 Adapta el idiom a la frase · Make the idiom fit

Completa con el idiom del paréntesis en la forma correcta: cambia el tiempo verbal, el posesivo o el pronombre, pero nunca las partes fijas.
Complete with the idiom in brackets in the correct form: change tense, possessive or pronoun, never the fixed parts.

1 I wish you would stop _____ and tell me what happened. (beat about the bush)

2 After three failed bids, the consortium finally _____ last week. (throw in the towel)

3 Yesterday I really _____ when I mentioned his ex-wife. (put your foot in it)

4 Don't believe a word he says: he's just _____. (pull someone's leg)

5 The two senators _____ since the scandal broke. (not see eye to eye)

6 She _____ when the scholarship letter arrived. (be over the moon)

7 By announcing the merger before the vote, the paper had _____. (jump the gun)

8 The new recruits are still _____, so be patient with them. (learn the ropes)

9 The buyer _____ at the last minute and pulled out of the sale. (get cold feet)

10 Since the funding was cut, all our research _____. (go down the drain)

Ejercicio 10 Caza el error · Find the mistake

✍️ Cada frase contiene UN error en el idiom (calco, palabra fija cambiada, número…). Escríbela bien.
🇬🇧 Each sentence has ONE mistake in the idiom. Write it correctly.

1 ✗ The renovation cost us an eye of the face.
✓ _____

2 ✗ After the third rejection, she threw the towel.
✓ _____

3 ✗ Sorry, what did you say? I was in the clouds.
✓ _____

4 ✗ Quantum physics sounds Chinese to me.
✓ _____

5 ✗ Stop beating about the bushes and get to the point.
✓ _____

6 ✗ This solution kills two birds with one shot.
✓ _____

7 ✗ The pay freeze was the drop that filled the glass.
✓ _____

8 ✗ I really put the leg when I asked about her husband.
✓ _____

Ejercicio 10 Caza el error · Find the mistake (continúa · cont.)

9 ✗ The minister is in hot waters over his expenses.
✓ _____

10 ✗ We're in the same ship, so let's help each other.
✓ _____

Ejercicio 11 Transformaciones tipo Cambridge · Key word transformations

✍️ Completa la segunda frase para que signifique lo mismo que la primera. Usa la palabra clave (sin cambiarla) y entre 3 y 8 palabras. La palabra clave activa un idiom.
🇬🇧 Complete the second sentence so that it means the same as the first. Use the key word, unchanged, and 3–8 words.

1 Please stop avoiding the issue and say what you mean.
→ I'd rather you _____ and said what you meant. (BUSH)

2 We paid a fortune for the holiday.
→ The holiday _____. (ARM)

3 It was Jane who accidentally revealed the secret about the merger.
→ The person _____ about the merger was Jane. (BAG)

Ejercicio 11 — Transformaciones tipo Cambridge · Key word transformations (continúa · cont.)

4 The minister has yet to declare which side he supports.
→ The minister is _____. (FENCE)

5 It is now up to the unions to respond to our offer.
→ The ball is now _____. (COURT)

6 It is very rare for us to eat out these days.
→ We _____ these days. (MOON)

7 Nobody in the audience found his attempt at humour remotely funny.
→ His attempt at humour _____ the audience. (FLAT)

8 The deal was only saved at the very last moment.
→ It was not until _____ the deal was saved. (HOUR)

Ejercicio 12 — Del idiom al registro formal · From idiom to formal register

✍️ Estas frases van a un informe oficial. Sustituye el idiom (en negrita) por una expresión neutra o formal.
🇬🇧 These sentences are for an official report. Replace the idiom in bold with neutral or formal wording.

1 The firm has been **in the red** for two years.

2 The negotiators **threw in the towel** after six hours.

3 Funding remains **a bone of contention** between the two departments.

4 The council **jumped the gun** by approving the plan.

5 Many households are struggling to **make ends meet**.

6 The report **hits the nail on the head**.

7 The opposition leader is **sitting on the fence** over the issue.

8 The minister is **in hot water** over his expenses.

Ejercicio 13 Lee y contesta · Read and answer

✍️ Lee el artículo. Marca T (verdadero) o F (falso) y contesta las preguntas con tus propias palabras.
🇬🇧 Read the article. Tick T or F and answer the questions in your own words.

The start-up that nearly wasn't

When Marta Ruiz left her job at a Madrid bank to launch a food-delivery app, her friends thought she had bitten off more than she could chew. She had no experience in technology, and for the first eighteen months the company was firmly in the red. To make ends meet, she gave Spanish lessons in the evenings; at night, she burnt the midnight oil coding the prototype herself.

The low point came when her main investor got cold feet and withdrew, just weeks before the launch. 'I was between a rock and a hard place,' she recalls. 'I could either throw in the towel or sell my flat to keep going.' She took the plunge and sold it, although her parents, she admits, did not see eye to eye with her on that decision.

In the end, losing the investor proved a blessing in disguise. A larger fund, impressed by her determination, stepped in at the eleventh hour. Today the app is the group's cash cow, and Ruiz is understandably over the moon. Her advice to young entrepreneurs? 'Learn the ropes before you start, and don't expect it to be a piece of cake.'

1 Marta's friends thought her plan was too ambitious for her. T F

2 The company made a profit from the very beginning. T F

3 Her main investor withdrew because he became nervous. T F

4 Marta's parents fully supported the sale of her flat. T F

Ejercicio 13 Lee y contesta · Read and answer (continúa · cont.)

5 How did Marta make ends meet during the first eighteen months?

6 What were the two options when she was 'between a rock and a hard place'?

7 Why did losing the investor turn out to be 'a blessing in disguise'?

8 Find an idiom in paragraph 3 meaning 'a reliable source of profit'.

9 Rewrite 'stepped in at the eleventh hour' in neutral language.

Ejercicio 14 Traduce al inglés · Translate into English

✍️ Traduce usando un idiom inglés. No traduzcas la imagen española: busca el equivalente.
🇬🇧 Translate using an English idiom. Find the equivalent, not the literal image.

1. 🇪🇸 Ese coche les costó un ojo de la cara.
   🇬🇧 _____
2. 🇪🇸 Deja de andarte con rodeos y dime la verdad.
   🇬🇧 _____
3. 🇪🇸 Tras el tercer rechazo, ella tiró la toalla.
   🇬🇧 _____
4. 🇪🇸 La subida de precios fue la gota que colmó el vaso.
   🇬🇧 _____
5. 🇪🇸 ¿Me estás tomando el pelo?
   🇬🇧 _____
6. 🇪🇸 El Gobierno está entre la espada y la pared.
   🇬🇧 _____
7. 🇪🇸 Metí la pata al preguntarle por su exmujer.
   🇬🇧 _____
8. 🇪🇸 Hemos hecho nuestra oferta: ahora la pelota está en su tejado (de ellos).
   🇬🇧 _____

Ejercicio 14 Traduce al inglés · Translate into English (continúa · cont.)

9. 🇪🇸 Perder aquel trabajo fue, al final, una suerte.
   🇬🇧 _____
10. 🇪🇸 Mi hermano viene a vernos de Pascuas a Ramos.
    🇬🇧 _____

Ejercicio 15 Ahora escribe tú · Your turn

✍️ Escribe en inglés. Cuida la forma exacta del idiom y el registro.
🇬🇧 Write in English. Watch the exact form of each idiom and the register.

1. Cuenta una ocasión en la que **metiste la pata** (put your foot in it). 2 frases.
   _____
   _____
2. Escribe un titular de prensa con **at the eleventh hour** o **in hot water**.
   _____
3. Aconseja a alguien que quiere dejar la carrera. Usa **throw in the towel** y **a blessing in disguise**.
   _____
   _____

Ejercicio 15 **Ahora escribe tú** · Your turn (continúa · cont.) ✍️

4 Dos frases sobre tu trabajo o tus estudios: una con **learn the ropes** y otra con **pull your weight**.

5 Reescribe este mensaje en tono formal: «We're in hot water: the budget's gone down the drain and the client's getting cold feet.»

¿Lo he aprendido? · Can I do it?

Marca cada frase cuando la sepas hacer y colorea las estrellas. Tick each line when you can do it and colour the stars.

Lo sé hacer · I can...

- [ ] Reconozco al menos **50 idioms** frecuentes y sé qué significan. ☆☆☆
  I recognise at least 50 common idioms and know what they mean.
- [ ] Sé qué partes de un idiom **cambian** (verbo, posesivo) y cuáles son **fijas**. ☆☆☆
  I know which parts of an idiom change and which are fixed.
- [ ] Evito los calcos: cost **an arm and a leg**, nunca ~~an eye of the face~~. ☆☆☆
  I avoid literal calques from Spanish.
- [ ] Distingo los idioms **coloquiales** de los **neutros** que acepta la prensa seria. ☆☆☆
  I can tell colloquial idioms from neutral ones.
- [ ] En un texto académico sustituyo un idiom coloquial por una **paráfrasis formal**. ☆☆☆
  I can paraphrase idioms in formal writing.
- [ ] Resuelvo **transformaciones tipo Cambridge C2** en las que la palabra clave activa un idiom. ☆☆☆
  I can do C2 key word transformations with idioms.

Mi progreso · My progress

Colorea 1, 2 o 3 estrellas en cada ejercicio. Colour 1, 2 or 3 stars for each exercise.

Ej. 1 ☆☆☆	Ej. 2 ☆☆☆	Ej. 3 ☆☆☆	Ej. 4 ☆☆☆
Ej. 5 ☆☆☆	Ej. 6 ☆☆☆	Ej. 7 ☆☆☆	Ej. 8 ☆☆☆
Ej. 9 ☆☆☆	Ej. 10 ☆☆☆	Ej. 11 ☆☆☆	Ej. 12 ☆☆☆
Ej. 13 ☆☆☆	Ej. 14 ☆☆☆	Ej. 15 ☆☆☆	

Solucionario · Answer key

Para el adulto que corrige (¡o para comprobar después de hacerlo!). For the grown-up who checks, or to check after you finish.

Mapa · Mini ejercicio

1. bush · **2.** cake · **3.** leg · **4.** court · **5.** towel

Ejercicio 1 · Idiom y significado

1-c · 2-e · 3-g · 4-b · 5-d · 6-f · 7-a · 8-h

Ejercicio 2 · Idiom y equivalente español

1-c · 2-f · 3-h · 4-e · 5-d · 6-b · 7-a · 8-g

Ejercicio 3 · Clasifica por tema

💰 **Trabajo y dinero:** make ends meet, be in the red, tighten your belt, a cash cow
💬 **Conflicto:** bury the hatchet, a bone of contention, get on someone's nerves, bite your tongue
❤️ **Emociones:** over the moon, down in the dumps, get cold feet, have a chip on your shoulder
🎲 **Decisiones y tiempo:** in the nick of time, at the eleventh hour, sit on the fence, take the plunge

Ejercicio 4 · La palabra fija

1. in · **2.** bush · **3.** leg · **4.** teacup · **5.** red · **6.** blue · **7.** nick · **8.** foot · **9.** straw · **10.** bridge

Ejercicio 5 · ¿Qué significa de verdad?

1. False ✗ — It is unlikely to succeed.
2. True ✓
3. False ✗ — It is a reliable source of profit.
4. True ✓
5. False ✗ — Nobody finds it funny.

Ejercicio 5 · ¿Qué significa de verdad? (continúa · cont.)

6. True ✓
7. False ✗ — It is losing money or in debt.
8. False ✗ — You stop yourself from saying it.
9. True ✓
10. True ✓

Ejercicio 6 · Completa el idiom

1. cake · **2.** hatchet · **3.** ropes · **4.** iceberg · **5.** plunge · **6.** fence · **7.** drain · **8.** ear · **9.** bell · **10.** weight

Ejercicio 7 · Español, idiom y significado

Español	Idiom	Meaning · significado
llegar a fin de mes	make ends meet	have just enough money to live on
dar en el clavo	hit the nail on the head	describe something exactly right
andarse con rodeos	beat about the bush	avoid the main point
no mojarse	sit on the fence	avoid taking sides
la manzana de la discordia	a bone of contention	a subject of disagreement
quemarse las pestañas	burn the midnight oil	work late into the night
estar metido en un lío	be in hot water	be in trouble
lanzarse a la piscina	take the plunge	finally do something risky
echarse atrás	get cold feet	become too nervous to go ahead
arrimar el hombro	pull your weight	do your fair share of the work

Ejercicio 8 · Ordena la frase

1. She finally threw in the towel.
2. It cost us an arm and a leg.
3. The ball is in your court now.
4. This is just the tip of the iceberg.
5. I had to bite my tongue.
6. We don't always see eye to eye.
7. Are you pulling my leg?
8. We'll cross that bridge when we come to it.
9. Many families are struggling to make ends meet.

Ejercicio 9 · Adapta el idiom a la frase

1. beating about the bush
2. threw in the towel
3. put my foot in it
4. pulling your leg
5. haven't seen eye to eye / have not seen eye to eye
6. was over the moon
7. jumped the gun
8. learning the ropes
9. got cold feet
10. has gone down the drain

Ejercicio 10 · Caza el error

1. The renovation cost us an arm and a leg.
2. After the third rejection, she threw in the towel.
3. Sorry, what did you say? I had my head in the clouds. / Sorry, what did you say? I was miles away.
4. Quantum physics is all Greek to me.
5. Stop beating about the bush and get to the point.
6. This solution kills two birds with one stone.

Ejercicio 10 · Caza el error (continúa · cont.)

7. The pay freeze was the last straw.
8. I really put my foot in it when I asked about her husband.
9. The minister is in hot water over his expenses.
10. We're in the same boat, so let's help each other.

Ejercicio 11 · Transformaciones tipo Cambridge

1. I'd rather you **stopped beating about the bush** and said what you meant.
2. The holiday **cost (us) an arm and a leg**.
3. The person **who let the cat out of the bag** about the merger was Jane.
4. The minister is **(still) sitting on the fence**.
5. The ball is now **in the unions' court**.
6. We **(only) eat out once in a blue moon** these days.
7. His attempt at humour **fell (completely) flat with** the audience.
8. It was not until **the eleventh hour that** the deal was saved.

Ejercicio 12 · Del idiom al registro formal

1. The firm has been **operating at a loss** (or **making a loss**) for two years.
2. The negotiators **abandoned their efforts** (or **conceded defeat**) after six hours.
3. Funding remains **a source of disagreement** (or **a contentious issue**) between the two departments.
4. The council **acted prematurely** in approving the plan.
5. Many households are struggling to **cover their basic living costs**.
6. The report **identifies the problem precisely** (or **is entirely accurate**).
7. The opposition leader **is remaining neutral** (or **has not taken a clear position**) on the issue.
8. The minister **is facing serious criticism** (or **is under scrutiny**) over his expenses.

Ejercicio 13 · Lee y contesta

1. True ✓ — They thought she had bitten off more than she could chew.
2. False ✗ — For eighteen months it was in the red.
3. True ✓ — He got cold feet.
4. False ✗ — They did not see eye to eye with her.
5. She gave Spanish lessons in the evenings.
6. Giving up (throwing in the towel) or selling her flat to keep going.
7. Because a larger fund, impressed by her determination, invested at the last moment.
8. a cash cow
9. intervened at the last possible moment

Ejercicio 14 · Traduce al inglés

1. That car cost them an arm and a leg.
2. Stop beating about the bush and tell me the truth.
3. After the third rejection, she threw in the towel.
4. The price rise was the last straw. / The price increase was the last straw.
5. Are you pulling my leg? / Are you taking the mickey?
6. The government is between a rock and a hard place.
7. I put my foot in it when I asked him about his ex-wife.
8. We've made our offer: the ball is in their court now.
9. Losing that job turned out to be a blessing in disguise.
10. My brother comes to see us once in a blue moon.

Ejercicio 15 · Ahora escribe tú

1. Ej.: At a dinner party I asked our host when the baby was due. I really put my foot in it: she wasn't pregnant.
2. Ej.: Strike averted at the eleventh hour as unions accept new pay offer.
3. Ej.: Don't throw in the towel just because you failed one exam. It may turn out to be a blessing in disguise.
4. Ej.: It took me a month to learn the ropes. Now everyone expects me to pull my weight.
5. Ej.: We are currently facing serious difficulties: the budget has been exhausted and the client is reconsidering their commitment.